Employee Handbook

Northstar Labs GmbH

2024 Edition

Effective January 1, 2024

Internal use only · Workshop demo document · Not a binding employment contract

About This Handbook

Northstar Labs GmbH provides this handbook to describe employment policies, benefits, workplace expectations, and conduct standards for all employees. It is not an employment contract and does not alter at-will employment where applicable.

Managers may implement additional team norms that remain consistent with these policies. When team norms and handbook language conflict, the handbook governs unless HR publishes an explicit exception.

How to Use This Document

Policies are organized by chapter. Section numbers (for example §3.2) are stable references for HR tickets, audits, and internal search. Always cite the section number when escalating a question.

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§1.1 Welcome

This handbook applies to all full-time and part-time employees. Policies are effective January 1, 2024 unless otherwise noted. HR publishes updates on the intranet; employees are responsible for reviewing changes within 30 days of notification.

Northstar Labs is an equal-opportunity employer. We hire, promote, and compensate based on qualifications, performance, and business need without regard to protected characteristics under applicable law.

Offer letters describe role, compensation, equity (if any), and probation terms. This handbook supplements but does not replace individual agreements. If your offer letter conflicts with a general policy, contact People Operations.

Probation periods are typically six months for new hires. Performance check-ins occur at 30, 90, and 180 days unless your manager schedules additional reviews. Successful completion of probation is required before certain benefits (for example internal transfer priority) take effect.

Chapter 2 - Employment Basics (continued)

Work authorization must remain valid for the duration of employment. Notify HR within five business days of any change to visa or permit status. Managers must not employ individuals who are not authorized to work in their assigned location.

Employment classifications (full-time, part-time, contractor) determine benefit eligibility. Contractors and vendors are not covered by this handbook unless a separate statement of work explicitly incorporates these policies.

Chapter 3 - Workplace & Attendance (overview)

This chapter covers office attendance, remote work, and collaboration norms. Hybrid and fully remote roles have different requirements - see §3.1 and §3.2. Team leads document core hours and on-call rotations in team playbooks compatible with these rules.

Office facilities are available Monday through Friday except on company holidays. Badge access is personal and must not be shared. Report lost badges to Security within 24 hours.

Chapter 4 - Collaboration Norms

Use the company calendar for PTO visibility and respect focus-time blocks. Async updates in Slack or email are preferred when colleagues are in different time zones. Default to written summaries after meetings that produce decisions affecting customers or cross-team commitments.

Meeting hygiene: agendas required for meetings longer than 30 minutes; optional attendees may decline without penalty. Recordings are for internal use only and must not be shared externally without Legal approval.

Travel between offices follows the expense policy in §6.3. Pre-approval is required for international travel and for domestic trips estimated above EUR 500.

§3.1 Office Attendance

All hybrid employees are expected in the office at least 2 days per week unless an approved remote-work exception applies. Team leads may set stricter team norms when customer or lab requirements demand it.

Failure to meet attendance expectations may trigger a performance review. Repeated unapproved absences from the office are treated as a conduct issue. Employees with medical or caregiving accommodations should work with HR on documented flexible arrangements.

Desk hoteling applies in Berlin and Munich offices. Reserve space through the workplace app before 5 PM the prior business day. Personal items left overnight may be removed during cleaning.

Workplace Health & Safety

Report hazards to facilities@northstarlabs.example. Emergency exits and assembly points are posted on each floor. Fire drills are mandatory; participation is tracked.

Ergonomic assessments are available for office and home setups. Submit a request through the HR portal; approved items may be expensed per §6.3 up to published limits.

Visitors must sign in at reception and wear visible badges. Employees hosting visitors are responsible for escorting them and ensuring NDA execution when required.

Remote Collaboration Standards

Video is encouraged for 1:1s and small group working sessions. Camera-off is acceptable for large forums and when bandwidth is limited. Use company-approved conferencing tools only; do not record customer calls without consent.

Response-time expectations: Slack within 4 business hours; email within 1 business day unless marked urgent. On-call engineers follow the paging policy in the Engineering wiki.

Chapter 5 - Time Off (overview)

Paid time off and sick leave policies are detailed on pages 13-14. Submit requests through Workday unless your region uses a local payroll provider.

Public holidays follow the official calendar for your work location. Floating holidays may be available in certain regions - see your offer letter or HR portal.

Extended leave beyond PTO (sabbatical, unpaid leave) requires VP approval and HR planning at least 8 weeks in advance. Benefits continuity during unpaid leave requires separate enrollment paperwork.

Leave Coordination

Managers must maintain team coverage plans for absences longer than three consecutive days. Hand off open customer issues and document in-flight work in the team tracker.

Company shutdown days (typically between Christmas and New Year) may require use of PTO in some regions. HR announces shutdown schedules by October 1 each year.

Preparing for §3.2 Remote Work

Hybrid and remote arrangements share core collaboration hours but differ on monthly remote-day caps and approval workflows. Read §3.1 together with §3.2 before submitting requests in the HR portal.

International remote work (working from a country other than your assigned entity) requires Legal and Tax review at least 6 weeks in advance and is not guaranteed.

§3.2 Remote Work

The following table summarizes remote work limits by arrangement. Hybrid employees must also comply with §3.1 office attendance.

Arrangement	Remote days / month	Advance notice	Core hours (local)
Hybrid	3	5 business days (HR portal)	10:00-15:00
Fully remote	Exempt from monthly cap	As agreed with manager	10:00-15:00

Hybrid employees may work remotely up to 3 days per calendar month, with manager approval required. Requests must be submitted at least 5 business days in advance via the HR portal.

Fully remote roles are exempt from the monthly day cap but must maintain core collaboration hours (10:00-15:00 local time). Temporary relocation during remote work must stay within approved tax jurisdictions.

Equipment and connectivity for remote work follow §7.2. The company does not reimburse coworking memberships unless pre-approved for roles without a suitable home workspace.

Chapter 5 - Time Off (overview)

Submit PTO and sick requests through Workday unless your region uses a local payroll provider. Managers should approve or decline within 2 business days.

§5.1 Paid Time Off

Full-time employees accrue 20 PTO days per year. PTO requests require manager approval in Workday at least 2 weeks before start date for trips longer than 5 consecutive days.

Unused PTO above 5 days rolls over to the next calendar year, capped at 10 days. Payout of unused PTO at termination follows local law and your employment agreement.

Part-time employees accrue PTO pro rata based on scheduled hours. PTO cannot be borrowed against future accrual except with HR exception for documented emergencies.

Blackout periods may apply for revenue-critical teams; HR publishes these by November for the following calendar year. PTO booked before a blackout announcement is grandfathered unless business continuity requires rescheduling.

§5.2 Sick Leave

Employees receive 10 paid sick days per year. Sick leave does not require advance approval; notify your manager before 9:30 AM on the first day absent.

A doctor's note is required for absences longer than 3 consecutive days. Sick leave may not be used for vacation purposes. Patterns of Monday/Friday absences may trigger a good-faith inquiry from HR.

Caregiver leave for ill family members may use sick balance where local law permits; otherwise apply for unpaid leave or PTO per regional guidance.

Public holidays follow the official calendar for your work location. Floating holidays may be available in certain regions - see your offer letter or HR portal.

Extended Leave & Sabbatical

Extended leave beyond PTO (sabbatical, unpaid leave) requires VP approval and HR planning at least 8 weeks in advance. Benefits continuity during unpaid leave requires separate enrollment paperwork.

Corporate card holders must reconcile transactions weekly. Personal purchases on company cards are prohibited and may result in payroll deduction or termination.

Learning and conference budgets require manager approval and must align with role development plans. Conference travel follows §6.3 pre-approval thresholds.

Chapter 6 - Benefits & Expenses (overview)

Keep receipts and submit claims within 30 days. Wellness stipends and learning budgets are described on the intranet and are separate from §6.3 reimbursements.

§6.1 Health Benefits

Medical, dental, and vision coverage begins on the first day of the month after your start date. Open enrollment is each November for changes effective January 1.

Dependents must be enrolled within 30 days of a qualifying life event. Domestic partner coverage requires submitted documentation per carrier rules.

Northstar Labs contributes a fixed percentage of premium costs; employee contributions are payroll-deducted pre-tax where permitted. COBRA or local equivalent notices are issued within statutory timelines upon separation.

Flexible spending and health savings arrangements vary by country; see the benefits portal for eligible expenses and submission deadlines.

§6.3 Expense Reimbursement

Submit expenses within 30 days via Concur with receipts. Home office stipend: up to EUR 50/month for internet when working remotely.

Travel must be pre-approved for amounts over EUR 500. Mileage is reimbursed at the published IRS or local rate depending on entity. Alcohol is reimbursable only for approved customer entertainment within per-head limits.

Gifts to customers or partners require pre-approval from your manager and must comply with the ethics rules in §11.2.

Chapter 7 - Equipment (overview)

Report lost or stolen devices to IT within 24 hours. Asset tags must remain visible on company hardware at all times.

§7.2 Equipment

Remote employees receive a laptop, monitor, and EUR 200 home-office setup allowance once per role. Equipment remains company property.

Return all hardware within 5 business days of offboarding. Failure to return equipment may delay final pay processing and trigger asset recovery procedures.

Software licenses are assigned through SSO groups. Do not install unapproved productivity tools that sync company data to personal accounts. BYOD is not supported for roles handling customer data.

Monitors and peripherals purchased with the home-office allowance become company property when reimbursed; retain receipts for audit.

§8.1 IT Security

Company laptops must use full-disk encryption and MFA on all SSO apps. Do not store customer PII on personal devices.

Report suspected phishing to security@ within 1 hour. VPN is required when accessing internal systems from public networks. Complete annual security training by March 31 each year.

Incident response playbooks are on the security wiki. When unsure, escalate to security@northstarlabs.example rather than investigating alone. Lost or stolen devices must be reported to IT within 24 hours.

§9.1 Parental Leave

Primary caregivers receive 16 weeks paid parental leave. Secondary caregivers receive 6 weeks. Leave must be taken within 12 months of birth or adoption placement.

Coordinate return dates with HR at least 4 weeks before end of leave. Benefits continuation during leave follows carrier rules; HR provides enrollment packets at leave start.

Parental leave runs concurrently with statutory leave where applicable. Employees planning adoption or surrogacy should contact HR early for jurisdiction-specific guidance.

Chapter 10 - Performance & Development

Annual review cycles run in Q1. Goals should align with team OKRs and company values. Calibration sessions ensure consistent ratings across departments.

Internal mobility is encouraged. Discuss transfer interest with your manager and HR before applying to open roles. A minimum of 12 months in role is expected unless reorg or business need dictates otherwise.

Chapter 11 - Conduct & Ethics (overview)

The code of conduct on page 22 defines non-negotiable behavior standards. Speak up early if you witness violations. Conflicts of interest must be disclosed to HR and your manager.

§11.2 Code of Conduct

Harassment, discrimination, and retaliation are prohibited. Report concerns to HR@ or the anonymous ethics hotline. All reports are investigated within 10 business days.

Retaliation against reporters is grounds for termination. Social media guidelines prohibit sharing confidential information or speaking on behalf of the company without communications approval.

Gifts from vendors above EUR 50 aggregate per year require approval. Whistleblower protections apply to good-faith reports.

Appendix A - Contacts

People Operations: people@northstarlabs.example · IT Helpdesk: helpdesk@northstarlabs.example · Security: security@northstarlabs.example · Ethics hotline: ethics@northstarlabs.example (anonymous option available)